# Class 9 Economics Ch – 03 Poverty as a Challenge - Street

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**Class 9 Economics Notes Ch – 03 Poverty as a Challenge**

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## Dimensions of Poverties

India has the largest single concentration of poor in the world. In India, nearly 260 million people live in poverty. Poverty means lack of food, shelter, education, clean water, sanitation facilities and a regular job for livelihood.

## Two Typical Cases of Poverty

The following two cases show the many dimensions of poverty, including lack of proper food, shelter, healthcare, education as well as clean water

and sanitation. They also show lack of a regular means of livelihood.

### (i) Urban Case

Ram Saran is a daily wage laborer in a flour mill near Ranchi in Jharkhand. He earns around Rs. 1500 per month when employed. He supports his family of 6 persons, besides sending some money to his elderly parents. His wife and son also work, but none of his 4 children can attend school. The family lives in a one-room rented house on the outer areas of the city; The children are undernourished, have very few clothes or footwear and no access to healthcare.

### (ii) Rural Case

Lakha Singh is a landless labourer in a small village near Meerut in Uttar Pradesh. By doing odd jobs for farmers, he earns Rs. 50 per day. Sometimes, he gets some foodgrain or other items instead of cash. He is not literate, and his family of 8 people lives in a kuccha hut near the edge of the village. They have no access to healthcare, cannot afford new clothes or even soap or oil.

## Poverty as Seen in Social Science

Poverty is analyzed through social indicators such as illiteracy level, lack of general resistance because of malnutrition, lack of access to healthcare and lack of job opportunities. Recently, the analysis of poverty is based on social exclusion and vulnerability.

Social exclusion can be both a cause and a consequence of poverty. It is the trend where individuals or groups are excluded from the privilege of benefits and opportunities which others enjoy.

The vulnerability of the poor is a measure which states the probability of particular communities or individuals of becoming poor in the future. It is identified through the options available to different communities for finding an alternative living style in terms of assets, education, health and job opportunities.

## Poverty Line in India

The poverty line is drawn with the levels of income or consumption of a person. If a person's income or consumption is not sufficient to meet basic requirements, then they are considered poor. Therefore, the poverty line varies with person, place and time.

➤ The minimum level of food requirement, clothing, footwear, fuel and light, and educational and medical assistance are determined to measure the poverty line. These physical quantities are multiplied by their price in rupees.

➤ While measuring the poverty line, the food requirement is based on the desired calorie intake. In India, the average calorie intake per person per day is 2,400 calories in rural areas and 2,100 calories in urban areas.

➤ In 2000, the poverty line for a person was fixed at Rs 328 per month in rural areas and Rs 454 per month in urban areas.

➤ In rural areas, a family of five members earning less than Rs 1,640 per month will remain below the poverty line. In urban areas, a minimum of Rs 2,270 per month would be needed to meet basic requirements.

The poverty line is estimated periodically by conducting sample surveys. Surveys are conducted by the National Sample Survey Organization.

## Poverty Estimates

For over two decades, the proportion of people living below the poverty line has declined substantially, but the number of poor remained stable at

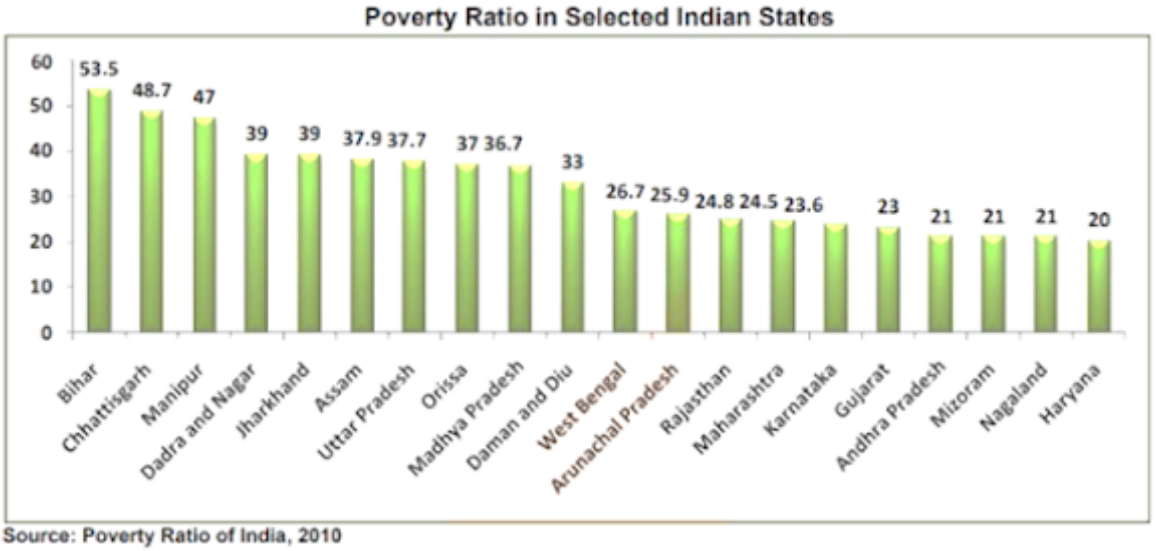
about 320 million for a long period. In 2000, an estimate indicates a significant reduction in the number of poor people at 260 million.

## Vulnerable Groups

In India, the people living below the poverty line are not the same for all social groups and economic categories. Social groups are the scheduled caste and schedule tribe households which are the most vulnerable section. The double disadvantage of being a landless casual wage labour household in the socially disadvantaged social groups of the scheduled caste or the scheduled tribe population highlights the seriousness of the problem. Gradually, in the 1990s, the poverty line declined for scheduled castes, rural agricultural labourers and urban casual labour except the scheduled tribe.

## Interstate Disparities

The proportion of poor people varies from state to state. Estimates show that the poverty ratio in states and union territories are less than the national average. Poverty Ratio in Selected Indian States.



Source: Poverty Ratio of India, 2010

## Global Poverty Scenario

In developing countries, the proportion of people living in extreme economic poverty has fallen from 28% in 1990 to 21% in 2001. Although global

poverty has reduced, regional differences do exist.

➤ Because of rapid economic growth, poverty has declined in China and South Asian countries.

➤ The number of poor in China has reduced from 606 million in 1981 to 212 million in 2001.

➤ Poverty has increased from 41% in 1981 to 46% in 2000 in Sub-Saharan Africa.

➤ In Latin America, the poverty ratio remained the same.

➤ The United Nations, through its Millennium Development Goals, has called for reducing the proportion of people living on less than $1 a day to half the 1990 level by 2015.

## Causes of Poverty

During the British colonial administration, there was a low level of economic development. British policies ruined the traditional method of making handicrafts and discouraged industrial development. This resulted in the failure of economic growth, population control and lack of job opportunities.

The Green Revolution with the spread of irrigation created many job opportunities in the agricultural sector. However, the benefit does not reach all parts of the country. Inadequate jobs and wage earners could not afford to run their family. Income inequality and many other socio-cultural and economic factors are responsible for poverty in India.

## Anti-Poverty Measures

The anti-poverty strategy of the Government is based on the promotion of economic growth and targeted anti-poverty programmers.

➤ National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA), September 2005

- ➪ 100 days assured employment every year to every household in 200 districts; will extend to 600 districts later.
- ➪ One-third of jobs reserved for women.
- ➪ The Central Government will establish National Employment Guarantee Funds.

➤ National Food for Work Programme (NFWP), 2004

- ➪ Launched in 150 most backward districts.
- ➪ Open to all rural poor who are in need of wage employment and manual skilled labour.
- ➪ 100% centrally sponsored scheme and food grains free of cost.

➤ Pradhan Mantri Gramodaya Yojana (PMGY), 2000

- ➪ Additional central assistance to states for basic services.

➤ Swarna Jayanti Gram Swarozgar Yojana (SGSY), 1999

- ➪ To assist poor families above the poverty line by organizing them into self-help groups through a mix of bank credit and government subsidy.

➤ Rural Employment Generation Programme (REGP), 1995

- ➪ To create self-employment opportunities in rural areas and small towns.
- ➪ To crate 25 lakh jobs for the programme under the Tenth Five-Year Plan.

➤ Prime Minister Rozgar Yojana (PMRY), 1993

- ➪ To create self-employment opportunities for educated unemployed youth in rural areas and small towns.
- ➪ To help set up small businesses and industries.

## Challenges Ahead

Although poverty has declined in India, there is a disparity between rural and urban areas and among different states. Great challenges include making better progress in reducing the poverty level in the next ten to fifteen years, providing minimum necessary health care, education, and job security for all and achieving gender equality in society.

## The Challenges to Poverty Reduction

Poverty reduction is still a major challenge in India, due to the wide differences between regions as well as rural and urban areas. Further, poverty should include not only the matter of the adequate amount of food

but other factors like education, healthcare, shelter, job security, gender, equality, dignity and so on.

These give us the concept of human poverty. Poverty reduction is expected to be lower in the next 10-15 years.

In addition to anti-poverty measures, the government should focus on the following to reduce poverty.

- ➤ Higher economic growth.
- ➤ Universal free elementary education.
- ➤ The decrease in population growth.
- ➤ Empowerment of women and weaker sections.